

Informed Consent Form: Expert Interview

Study Title: Comparing Expert and Non-Expert Security Practices
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Introduction and Purpose of the Study

This study aims to identify differences and similarities in IT security practices between experts and non-experts, as well as to examine how these practices are perceived by experts and non-experts.

Description of the Research

The survey contains questions regarding your practices to keep yourself safe online. The questionnaire contains multiple-choice questions (with the possibility to clarify in free-text response), open-ended questions, and demographic questions regarding your age, gender, workplace, and location of education. Participants will be asked some questions before starting the survey. The interview process requires the participants to think-aloud while answering the questionnaire.

Participation Requirements

Participants have to be over the age of 18 to be able to provide informed consent.

As the survey will be administered exclusively in English, participants must have at least an intermediate level of English proficiency to meaningfully engage with the questions and provide reliable responses.

We require the expert participants to have at least one year of work or study experience in IT security or a related field.

Potential Risks and Discomforts

There are no known risks for the participation in this study.

Confidentiality

Results from this study including anonymized quotes from the interview may be presented at conferences or published in scientific journals. As all data is anonymized, it is not possible to draw any conclusions about your identity.

Parts of this study are conducted using Qualtrics questionnaire software. Surveys and data are stored on Qualtrics servers in the EU and are accessible via password-protected user accounts. All data downloaded from Qualtrics servers is stored on an encrypted solid state drive.

Please note that after your completion of the survey, all data will be anonymized and therefore deletion of their data is no longer possible from this point on.

Notes taken throughout the interview will not contain any identifying information and will be securely stored on an encrypted solid state drive.

Compensation

There will be no compensation for the participation in this interview.

Voluntary Participation and Authorization

Your participation in this study is entirely voluntary. Choosing not to participate or deciding to withdraw from the study at any point will have no negative consequences. If you choose to take part, you may discontinue your participation at any time without penalty or any other negative effects. You have the right to information, correction, deletion, restriction of processing, data portability, as well as a right of appeal to a supervisory authority of your choice.

This study was reviewed in accordance with Saarland University ERB guidelines for research involving human subjects.

Contact

Should you have any questions about the study or your participation, please contact Lisa Hoffmann (s8lihof2@stud.uni-saarland.de)

Audio Recording and Transcription

With your permission, this interview will be audio recorded. Recording the conversation helps ensure that no important details are missed and allows the interviewer to focus fully on the discussion without the distraction of extensive note-taking. The recording will be used solely for the purposes of transcription and analysis within the scope of this research. The transcription will be anonymized, to not contain any identifying information.

If you consent, the audio recording of the first part of the study — excluding the questionnaire evaluation — may be transcribed using third-party transcription software that adheres to strict data protection standards (e.g., GDPR). These tools are selected based on their security protocols and commitment to confidentiality. Please note that the transcription of the interview may be performed using a third-party transcription service, which may include artificial intelligence (AI) functionality as part of its processing. All audio recordings will be stored securely and separately from identifying information. Only the research team will have access to the recordings and transcripts. Recordings will be permanently deleted after transcription and verification are complete, or no later than 1 year after the interview.

Please note that declining to be recorded or to allow transcription by software will not affect your eligibility to participate in the study.

Please indicate your consent to the following:

- I consent to the audio recording of my interview for research purposes.

☐ Yes ☐ No

- I consent to the use of secure third-party transcription software for transcribing my interview.

☐ Yes ☐ No

By signing below, you confirm that:

- You have read and understood the information above
- You are at least 18 years of age
- You voluntarily agree to participate in this study

Place, Date

Name, Signature